exchange of information and experiences on the building of socialism is a firm constituent of this close cooperation. In this, we learn from one another, as is usual between friends. Life again and again confirms that socialism is not a rigid and unchanging structure, as it is portrayed in the West. Newly developing issues and problems of social development require new ways and solutions. It is only important that each country recognises this in time and finds solutions that are relevant to the existing concrete conditions.

Of course, we, too, in the GDR, as in other socialist countries, have undertaken necessary structural changes. I would remind you that for years we have been orientated toward the comprehensive intensification of production, as well as toward the speeding up of production and the application of key technologies, microelectronics in particular. This has put us in the position of continuing our tried and trusted course of the unity of economic and social policy, in spite of complicated international conditions. A very important step on our side was the creation at the end of the 1970s and the beginning of the 1980s of the combines, which today form the backbone of our economy. Measures for raising the autonomy of combines and factories were resolved and are having positive effects. Therefore, we are not ‘anti-reform’, but are constantly checking where changes are necessary and how they are to be affected. To this end, many broad consultations and discussions are held about this, in which millions of citizens participate. The basic principle is: We will make changes when it is necessary and do that which serves the further strengthening of socialism and the well-being of our people.7

During 1988, Honecker’s health slipped as he endured several bouts of influenza, muscle weakness and lack of vitality. Even his daily shot of lemon juice failed to ward off illness. Physically, his back was slightly bent, his vocal cords strained, and he had lost considerable weight.

On the work front, while cheered by Moscow’s pledge to start a pull-out from Afghanistan and withdraw nuclear missiles from the GDR, he was irked by a stream of homilies on perestroika and glasnost appearing in the socialist press. Among these, the former Czech leader, Alexander Dubček